

“Loyalty by Lack of Virtue in *The Decameron* and *The Merchant of Venice*”

Giovanni Boccaccio's *The Decameron* functions as a frame story composed of shorter narratives. This fragmented composition allows for a metatextual echoing of broader ideas about loyalty, deception, and how the two intersect. Of its shorter narratives, *The Decameron*'s “Third Day Tenth Story” ironically subverts the assumption that individuals, by their vocation or piety, are incorruptible or that their behaviors and beliefs will be consistent with each other. In destabilizing this assumption, the text interrogates the ties between an individual's identity and character, especially with regard to how that individual might demand or fulfill loyalties to other characters. In *The Decameron*'s “Epilogue,” Boccaccio takes on the narrative voice to aversively superpose ideas of virtue and corruption onto his audience— seemingly of pre-plague ladies in love, but undeniably inclusive of the modern reader by extension. Despite being a product of a very different time, William Shakespeare's *The Merchant of Venice* sets aside similar presuppositions to interrogate how loyalty and deception might be irrespective of the characters that supply and compel them. Whether read as an anti-semitic text or a text exploring anti-semitic ideas, *The Merchant of Venice* traverses loyalty amidst a religious tension glossed over airily by *The Decameron*'s “Third Day Tenth Story.” Nevertheless, both texts bear remarkably renewed relevance in the post-pandemic modern world, not unfamiliar with anti-semitic ideologies. In their metatextual tug-of-war between loyalty and deception, the texts undertake ambiguous explorations of a loyalty-deception continuum: negotiated by desire in *The Decameron*, character in the *The Merchant of Venice*, and religion in both. Rather than treat loyalty as a consistent, ethical ideal, the two texts layer ironic narrative structures and character motives to present loyalty as a flexible construct that intersects with deception, religious identity,

and character, and at times even a tool that can itself mask duplicity and function as a means of manipulation.

The focal point of deception in *The Decameron*'s "Third Day Tenth Story" lies in the monk Rustico's succumbing to sexual desire, "[c]asting aside pious thoughts, prayers, and penitential exercises... to concentrate his mental faculties upon the youth and beauty of the girl" (12). Ironically, the young girl, Alibech, encounters Rustico on her search for how to "best serve God" (12). It is neither difficult nor unbased to define faith in close relation to loyalty, and the thematic proximity between Alibech's pursuit of loyalty via service to the divine and Rustico's manipulation of this for deceptive fulfillment of his own desires suggests a blurring of the boundaries between loyalty and deception. In the betrayal of his loyalty by faith and vocation, Rustico delivers to Alibech a "long speech... [on] all the ways of serving God,... [particularly] putting the devil back in Hell" (12). Alibech's naive piety in the text acts loosely as a form of spiritual loyalty; a desire to align her actions with service to the divine. However, her trust in Rustico's vocation enables instead his acts of deception. The metatextual euphemism of "putting the devil back in Hell," is the most significant mark of this— a distortion of religious language underpinned by lust and individual desire. Loyalty in *The Decameron*'s "Third Day Tenth Story" is highly ironic; the more faithfully Alibech follows Rustico's instruction on serving God, the further she is led from her spiritual goal of loyal service to the divine, and the more deeply entrenched she becomes in deception. Loyalty becomes an illusion produced by and despite authority and miscommunication. It is difficult to make the argument that Alibech is disloyal; it is easier, perhaps, to argue that her loyalty is weaponized by someone presumed to be virtuous and loyal in faith. The irony of Boccaccio's narrative hinges on a juncture between social role

and personal desire. The humor of the story then depends on the reader's recognition of this disjunction, implicating them in the ethical instability of loyalty.

Character in *The Merchant of Venice* functions in tandem with religious identity; perhaps so classically and stereotypically so that they enable re-assessment of the relationship between character and religious identity, and what it means for an individual's character in terms of loyalty and deception. This is most evident in the foils of Shylock and Antonio. Shylock, a Jewish moneylender, has an unyielding loyalty to the bond he makes with Antonio, rooted not only in legal rigor, but perhaps also in a desire for respect and vengeance. For his character, this insistence on his "pound of flesh" perhaps emerges from the rare opportunity to assert agency in a society that marginalizes him because he is a Jew. This loyalty, however, is cast as monstrous by the Christian characters of the text. Unlike Alibech, Shylock is not deceived by others so much as vilified for his unwavering fidelity to the letter and law. His loyalty becomes a fault precisely because it opposes the Christian value of mercy. Ironically, the Christians in the play deceive Shylock while framing their actions as morally superior. Portia's deception is legally clever, but ethically ambiguous; especially ironic given she seems to be an allegory for "the quality of mercy... the gentle rain from heaven" (4.1.183). Despite her famous polemic, she spares Shylock no mercy other than advising him to beg the Duke (4.1.362). She maintains loyalty to Bassanio, but only through deception—her courtroom performance and later testing of the ring he gives away further blur the lines between loyalty and deception. This is a striking parallel to Rustico in *The Decameron*. Both he and Portia weaponize knowledge and social power to manipulate others under the guise of loyalty or justice. However, where Boccaccio's text is steeped in irony and laughter, Shakespeare's text maintains a serious tone that frames Shylock's downfall as just, even as it concomitantly complicates that judgment, "[w]hat

judgment shall I dread, doing no wrong?” (4.1.89). Shylock is forced to convert to Christianity—an act portrayed not as spiritual salvation but as a final erasure of his identity. Here, religious loyalty is both demanded and violated. Shylock’s “Jewishness” is incompatible with Venetian society, regardless of how loyal he may be to its legal system.

Religion, although still highly salient in *The Decameron*’s “Third Day Tenth Story,” functions in unique opposition to *The Merchant of Venice*. The text presents an ironic disparity between an individual’s religious identity and their actions. Rustico, after being introduced as “a young hermit, [and] a very devout and kindly fellow,” immediately succumbs, in the paragraph following, to temptation and desire for the “lovely and graceful” Alibech (12). Where *The Decameron*’s “Third Day Tenth Story” shows an individual’s religious identity clashing with their actions, *The Merchant of Venice* links the religious identity of the individual tightly to their character and actions. In *The Decameron*, the “Third Day Tenth Story” being set at a Christian-Muslim intersection acts more as an incidental backdrop for the text’s humorous critique of religious hypocrisy. Rustico’s fallibility is a clear indicator of how little his religious identity dictates his actions. Conversely, the situation of *The Merchant of Venice* in, of course, Venice— an easternmost place of “otherness”— is highly reflective of the Christian-Judaism contention that the text hinges upon. The Christian characters are expected to be merciful and loyal, whereas the Jewish character is associated with vengefulness and rigidity. This essentialist thinking frames the text’s ethical ambiguity. Antonio insults and abuses Shylock, but is somehow the one who receives mercy. The classic and comedic Shakespeare ending asks the reader to cheer for its resolution, even as it concomitantly raises serious questions about justice, prejudice, and fairness.

The Decameron's "Epilogue" complicates its moral universe with metatextual implications. Boccaccio addresses his readers—defined in the text, but also clearly extensive to the modern reader—to preemptively defend the licentiousness of his stories. He claims that storytelling is a form of amusement, not moral instruction. Yet this framing itself is metatextual: it acknowledges the gap between narrative and meaning, and between virtue and entertainment. The ironic stance invites the reader to question what loyalty to religious or social codes really means, if and when hypocrisy is the norm. Boccaccio abstains from a clean resolution, instead insisting that the contradictions themselves are worth examining. In interesting contrast, *The Merchant of Venice* ends with apparent harmony—lovers are reunited, justice is supposedly served, and promises are kept. Yet the cost of this harmony (Shylock's erasure) haunts the resolution. Just as Boccaccio implicates his reader in the enjoyment of moral failure, Shakespeare leaves the reader uneasy. The loyalty that binds Portia to Bassanio and Antonio to his friends is constructed on exclusion and domination. Those who challenge or threaten this social order are expelled or reshaped to fit (conversion).

Loyalty in the two texts is neither a pure nor a static virtue. It is presented more so as a performance, demanded unequally and twisted by context. Alibech's faith is manipulated through desire; Shylock's legal fidelity is punished for its inflexibility. The reader can only presume the degree of intentionality with which Boccaccio and Shakespeare directed sympathies in their texts, but the general order of character sympathies suggests loyalty as indistinguishable from deception. Rather than clarifying the value of loyalty, *The Decameron* and *The Merchant of Venice* expose its ethical instability, asking readers to examine not only whom we are loyal to, but why and at what cost.

Works Cited

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